

On a particularly bad day at work, I typed the words “extreme early retirement” into the search box on my computer screen. Up popped what would become the first blog I ever read, Early Retirement Extreme (ERE). My life was changed forever!

I dove headfirst into the world of Jacob Lund Fisker at ERE and took on the journey through his “21 Day Makeover” to early retirement. It included ways to get our expenses as low as possible to be able to retire as soon as possible. On day three, Fisker’s program suggested I could “learn to cook based on a small set of staples (rice, beans, onions). These staples are then bought in 10 lbs bags.” I guess my love of sushi and microbrews would have to go.

On day seven, Fisker suggested “going car free.” On subsequent days, he advised getting rid of the cell phone, cable TV, and most of the other things that I associated with a normal life. He shared how he was able to live on under \$10,000 per year. It seemed like a lot of sacrifices, but it might just be worth it. I wanted out of the standard American lifestyle, and I wanted out bad. I thought I found my ticket.

I found my tribe among Financial Independence, Retire Early (FIRE) bloggers. They showed me that the life I dreamed of could